

HOUSE BILL 291

By Gant

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,
Chapter 7; Title 49, Chapter 8 and Title 49,
Chapter 9, relative to higher education.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 7, Part 1, is amended by adding the following as a new section:

(a) The institute of American civics at the University of Tennessee, Knoxville shall develop materials and curricula for a baccalaureate degree program that meets the requirements of this subsection (a) and distribute the materials and curricula developed to each public institution of higher education in this state. The curricula must be for a course of instruction that is three (3) semester hours, or the equivalent, in American government or American history that provides a comprehensive overview of the major events and turning points of American history and government and, at a minimum, includes:

- (1) An understanding of the United States Constitution;
- (2) An understanding of the Declaration of Independence;
- (3) An understanding of a minimum of five (5) essays from the Federalist

Papers as selected by the course instructor;

- (4) An understanding of the Emancipation Proclamation;
- (5) An understanding of the Gettysburg Address;
- (6) An understanding of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr.'s letter from

Birmingham jail; and

(7) An understanding of at least one (1) additional document that is foundational to the African-American freedom struggle.

(b) Each public institution of higher education that offers a baccalaureate degree program shall offer a course of instruction that includes the curricula developed pursuant to subsection (a) beginning no later than the 2025-2026 academic year. A public institution of higher education shall ensure that the course of instruction includes the administration of a cumulative final examination at the conclusion of the course, testing a student's proficiency on the documents described in subdivisions (a)(1)-(7).

(c)

(1) Beginning with the entering freshmen in the 2025-2026 academic year, each student of a public institution of higher education shall complete at least three (3) semester hours, or the equivalent, of a course of instruction that is offered pursuant to subsection (b) prior to the student obtaining a baccalaureate degree from a public institution of higher education, except as provided in subdivision (c)(2).

(2) A student who completes at least three (3) semester hours, or the equivalent, in an advanced placement, international baccalaureate, or dual credit course for which the instruction includes the requirements of subdivisions (a)(1)-(7) and the course included the administration of a cumulative final examination at the conclusion of the course, testing a student's proficiency on the documents described in subdivisions (a)(1)-(7), satisfies the requirements of subdivision (c)(1).

(d) Each governing board of a public institution of higher education shall ensure that the requirements of this section are incorporated into the degree requirements of all

baccalaureate degree programs offered by the public institution of higher education in a manner that does not:

- (1) Add to the total amount of credit hours for any degree; or
- (2) Conflict with any school accreditation process.

(e) Each governing board of a public institution of higher education shall ensure that the public institution of higher education under the governing board's jurisdiction is in compliance with this section. Each governing board shall annually submit a report to the chair of the education committee of the senate, the chair of the finance, ways and means committee of the senate, the chair of the committee of the house of representatives having jurisdiction over higher education, and the chair of the committee of the house of representatives having jurisdiction over finance that provides proof of the public institution's compliance or noncompliance with this section.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it.